

on your correspondent's screen. You therefore have to be careful about how you present your text. This section will discuss the problems that may arise from a mismatch between the sending and receiving software, and show how to avoid them.

Fancy Text

Some e-mail reading software only understands plain text. Italics, bold, and color changes will show up as control sequences in the text. You might send something like:

Hiya! Hey, I loved the presentation you gave to Jack this morning. Great Job!

but if your correspondent's software can't handle formatting, the message could show up as:

Hiya! Hey, I <I>loved<I> the presentation you gave to Jack this morning. Great Job!

Web documents are particularly difficult to read with older e-mail programs. You may have a choice of sending the web page as text or as HTML; keep your correspondent's capabilities in mind when you make that choice.

Web Links

Some e-mail reading software will recognize URLs (Uniform Resource Locators, or web addresses) in the text and make them "live." While some software recognizes URLs from the "www.", most software recognizes URLs by the http:// at the front. Thus, if there is a URL in your e-mail, it is much safer to include the http://!

Attachments

Some mailers support "attachments", where you can specify a document to send through e-mail. This allows people to share essentially any file in any format. GIF-encoded Picture images, Word documents, PDF files, Excel spreadsheets, and executable files are just